

Burning Man Project Editorial Guidelines

Updated February 2026

Purpose & Usage

The intention of these guidelines is to improve consistency and effectiveness in our communications across all channels and through all departments.

This is Burning Man Project's editorial style guide for all public-facing content and copy — including the website, blog, press releases, social media channels, internal and external email lists, printed materials (WhWhWh, Survival Guide, Tip Sheet, etc.), staff handbooks (training, team manuals, etc), and any other official communications materials. If you write or storytell for Burning Man nonprofit in any way, you should adhere to these guidelines. Questions or suggestions for additions to these guidelines can be directed to communications@burningman.org.

Audiences

Core - Black Rock City and Regional Event participants, both past and current. Includes Burning Man Project and event staff, volunteers, donors, and active members of Regional communities. They read the Burning Man Journal and Jackrabbit speaks, are the core audience for Burning Man LIVE, and are often on internal team email lists and discussion groups.

Curious - Fans of Burning Man, and people who aspire to go to Black Rock City or a Regional Event. They may be festivalgoers or consumers of culture, or belong to adjacent communities and organizations. They may have attended an event in the past, and are thinking of coming back to BRC. They may subscribe to the Jackrabbit Speaks, but they primarily engage with Burning Man content via social media.

General Public - The general public, who may or may not have heard about Burning Man before. They may have family members who participate, or they may have seen media or

social content about Burning Man. Some members of the public have misconceptions about Burning Man, based on salacious media reports. Others are aware of Burning Man as an arts and culture event or community.

Tone

Relatable – When creating content for any platform or channel, it must feel relatable (human-to-human) to core, curious and general public audiences.

Accessible – Burning Man Project's audiences are diverse and international, and English may or may not be their first language. Minimize and/or explain jargon. Spell out acronyms at first mention.

Actionable – Wherever possible, include some form of call-to-action to encourage audiences to learn more or take the next step in their engagement with Burning Man.

Inclusive :

- When representing Burning Man Project, always use first-person plural (we/our) language.
- When representing the Black Rock City community, or the broader Burning Man community, be inclusive without using we / our language. When possible, let the community speak for itself; when not possible, be specific about the community you're addressing, i.e.: "artists in the Burning Man global cultural movement," "the staff and crews that build Black Rock City."
- Be judicious about using the word "Burner" in public-facing comms. If you're writing for our core audience, Burners may be the correct word to use. But if you are writing for curious or public audiences, referring to them, or community members, as Burners could feel exclusionary; broaden your language to incorporate current, new, and future participants in the Burning Man community.

Avoid profanity.

Do not mention or display drugs, illegal activity, sex, or nudity.

Tone per Communications Channel

For press releases, nonprofit news, and donor communications use a formal professional voice.

Example: People naturally come to us with ideas for how they can create participatory events and experiences, support community resilience, or carry out disaster relief work. We give them tools and knowledge to create projects and events that are decommodified, participatory and inspired by our culture.

For website and *Journal* copy, use an accessible, casual yet not overly wordy voice.

Example: The best way to experience art in Black Rock City is to make it. Just remember there are a lot of ways to do that in a city that is in every sense an art project, assembled each year from the ground up.

For the Jackrabbit Speaks newsletter, use an accessible, whimsical voice that is concise.

Example: Creative souls everywhere are on a Burning Man juggernaut, imagining, planning, and building the world's most wondrous ephemeral city. This is your official invitation to join an adventure of joyful connection and creativity in Black Rock City 2026.

For social media posts, use a friendly voice that is even MORE concise.

Example: These Black Rock City Honoraria artworks began as shared experiments in creativity. Today, they show up in the real world — sparking awe, joy, and interactivity in everyday places.

Style, Punctuation, and Grammar

When in doubt, refer to Associated Press (AP) style.

Addresses in Black Rock City: Use a time and radial format with an ampersand. In most cases, write the time first: 6:15 & J. However, if the address is on Esplanade, write the street name first: Esplanade & 4:00. Plazas are written this way: 3:00 Plaza. Center Camp addresses are written as follows: Center Camp Plaza @ 7:00 based on where a camp is located clockwise around the plaza with 12:00 being toward the Man. [More about writing BRC addresses.](#) If a Black Rock City address needs to be specific, ask the Placement team.

Ampersands: Don't use an ampersand (&) in copy; use "and." except in the case of BRC addresses — i.e. 9:00 & C.

Capitalization in Headlines: Use title case. Capitalize the first word and all words except articles and prepositions shorter than four letters.

Commas: We use oxford commas.

Dates: When writing copy for the website, never say “this year” — be specific, say 2011.

Editorial notes: Editorial notes should be placed in [brackets].

Em dashes: Use em dashes (option shift -) with spaces around them — like this.

Hyphenated words in Headlines: Only capitalize the first word of a hyphenated word in a headline.

Numbers: Numbers less than 10 are spelled out (e.g. “nine”). Numbers 10 and higher are not spelled out (e.g. 11). When a sentence starts with a number, it’s always spelled out.

Periods: Single-space after periods.

Time: 11:59 pm PT 12 noon PT

Time zones: PT / ET / CET. We do not use daylight savings time designation, i.e.: PST or PDT. For virtual events, be sure to list the event in the three main time zones where our participants live: PT / ET / CET.

Burning Man Project Publications

Playa events are listed in the *WhatWhereWhen guide* (not the What Where When guide), which can be shortened after first mention to the WhWhWh.

The blog is the *Burning Man Journal*, or the *Journal* for short.

The Survival Guide for [year] or the [year] *Survival Guide*.

The [year] Dispatch. Or simply *The Dispatch*.

The Jackrabbit Speaks is written in full to public and curious artists who may be unfamiliar with the newsletter. Can subsequently be shortened to JRS and also written as JRS to core audiences.

Writing Photo Credits

Art Photo Credits

"Art Title" by Artist Name, Year (Photo by Photographer Name)

For example:

"Flock" by Michael Christian, 2001 (Photo by Scott Beale)

Art Photo Credits at a Regional Event

"Art Installation" by Artist/Collective at Event Name, Year (Photo by Photographer Name)

For example:

"Robot Resurrection" by Shane Evans at Sideburn, 2015 (Photo by Bob Jones)

Terminology and Usage

Burning Man and the Burning Man Project Nonprofit

Burning Man is everything we are and do — the global cultural movement, Black Rock City and other events, the Regional Network, and so on. Never write BM or BMan. Do not use the word "brand" to describe Burning Man's presence in the world, or in any other reference to the event, the culture or the organization.

Burning Man Project is used when referencing the legal nonprofit entity. You can refer to us as Burning Man Project, the Burning Man Project nonprofit, or the nonprofit Burning Man Project. You can write "the nonprofit" but not "the organization." Never write: BMorg, the Org, or the BORG. We write nonprofit, all one word, not non-profit or not-for-profit.

Year-round Burning Man Project initiatives are "programming" (like art grants) or facilitating "experiences" (like Black Rock City), depending on the case.

The Regional Network

An official Regional Event or **Regional Burn** is a local, community-produced event sanctioned by Burning Man Project. You can also use **Regional** to refer to a group, area, or event.

A Regional Contact (or RC for short) is a local volunteer who serves as a link between the Burning Man Project and Regional Burning Man communities worldwide. Someone who is not a Regional Contact but plays an active role locally is a “community leader.”

Burning Man Founders

Larry Harvey is the founder of Burning Man. Together with Jerry James, Larry built and burned the first Man on Baker Beach, but, more importantly, he saw the potential of these early Burns to have a far-reaching and positive effect on the world.

There are six co-founders who together built the modern-day event and organization and were previously the Black Rock City LLC members. Taken individually, they are each “one of the founders of Burning Man”. When Larry is accompanied by one of the other five, he too becomes a “co-founder.” [Visit this page](#) for details on how to write individual founder roles and titles.

Culture and Principles

Write “Burning Man culture,” not “Burner culture.”

For formal writing use “Burning Man’s 10 Principles,” “the 10 Principles” or “the 10 Principles of Burning Man.” Don’t use “ten principles” (uncapitalized) or “10p.”

Do not refer to “the default world.” Everyone who experiences Burning Man brings it back into their lives in very individual ways, removing the barrier between Burning Man and the rest of their lives.

Volunteer refers to everyone who gifts their time to build Black Rock City, including theme camp participants, art crews, city builders, performers, etc. Do not limit this term to Black Rock City crews. However, for clarity, especially where recruitment is concerned, you can refer to volunteer crews as “volunteers.”

Staff is the correct word to describe paid and unpaid Burning Man Project and Black Rock City teams — including people on volunteer crews, as well as contractors, temporary, and year-round staff.

Black Rock City-specific Terminology

Black Rock City is an event or a city, NOT a festival. You can refer to it as **Black Rock City** or **the Burning Man event in Black Rock City**. Do not refer to it as the Gerlach Regional. Do not call it the Burning Man event; there are Burning Man events around the world. Black Rock City can be abbreviated to BRC after first usage.

Never translate “Burning Man,” it is always expressed in English.

People don’t “attend Black Rock City.” They “participate in Black Rock City.”

Black Rock Ranger is the correct way to write it, not Black Rock City Ranger, not Burning Man Ranger.

The Burn is capitalized when referring to Black Rock City, the Man Burn, or a Regional Event. **The Man Burn** and **The Temple Burn** are written in title case.

Burner is capitalized.

The Man is gender-neutral, and thus is an “it,” not a “he.”

Mutant Vehicles are licensed by the DMV in Black Rock City, not art cars. The term “art car” is typically used outside of Black Rock City.

MOOP is written in all caps, as it is an acronym for Matter Out of Place. Always define it when writing public-facing communications. Moopy is acceptable when speaking to core audiences who understand the context.

The Temple in Black Rock City is capitalized.

Always write **playa** in lower case.

Businesses who are permitted by BLM and serve participants through the Outside Service Providers (OSS) program are service providers, not “vendors.” Though they are considered vendors in the outside world, we don’t use that term when referring to their work in Black Rock City.

Names of Things (and whether they’re capitalized)

Alternative Energy Zone (AEZ)

Arctica (formerly Camp Arctica)

The ARTery

Black Rock City Airport (88NV)

Black Rock City Gate (not gate)
Black Rock Rangers
BLM (also: the BLM)
BMIR (Burning Man Information Radio)
Burn Gardens
Burner Profile (singular) and Burner Profiles (collectively)
Burners Without Borders (can be shortened to BWB after the first mention)
The Burning Man Journal
Center Camp Plaza (the whole of Center Camp circle)
Center Camp defines the Center Camp Plaza and Canopy
Center Camp Canopy defines just the giant tent in Center Camp
The Communications team (not Team... "team" is always lowercase after the team's name)
Deep-playa Music Zone (DMZ)
Department of Mutant Vehicles (DMV)
Earth Guardians
Emergency Services Department (ESD)
Exodus
Fire Conclave
gray water
Greeters
Hushville
Ticket Sale Kid's Ticket (singular) and Kids' Tickets (plural)
Ticket Aid (formerly the Low Income Ticket)
Lamplighters
Lost and Found
Main Sale
Man Pavilion (not Man Base)
Media Mecca
mutant vehicle
OMG Sale
Playa Info
porta-potty (not porto)
Recycle Camp
Secure Ticket Exchange Program (STEP)
Stewards Sale
the Esplanade
the Man

the Temple

theme camp (also art support camp, mutant vehicle camp, work support camp)

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